There was something salvageable from what remained a naturally talented group that needed direction. At a post-tour meeting at Loughborough we set the collective goal of being the world's best. We needed the certainty of that target. A home Ashes series beckoned that summer, and beyond that, in the winter of 2010–11, lay the acid test of a series Down Under. It was a relief to concentrate on cricket, knowing that Flower and Strauss had the authority to take things forward.

The group had been fractured during the preceding tour of India by the magnitude of events and the misplaced force of personality. Dressing rooms inevitably breed alpha males, and friction had become wearing. KP's relationship with Freddie Flintoff was extremely difficult; the tension between KP and Moores was equally marked.

Comfort is an alien concept in elite sport, which cannot be allowed to become too relaxed because it is by nature intense and all-consuming. Our issues had been complicated immeasurably by the fallout from the terrorist attacks in Mumbai in November 2008. We had suffered a fifth consecutive defeat to India in a scheduled seven-match one-day series when news filtered through.

I had been recalled to the team and opened with my county teammate Ravi Bopara. Since we had never done so for Essex, let alone England, it typified a squad searching, with increasing urgency, for balance and impetus. It was a quiet, hour-long journey back to the team hotel; like many, I dozed fitfully. Mobile phone coverage was intermittent, at best, but I suddenly received a text from a friend: 'Are you OK?'

Others were obviously getting the same sort of messages, because people were whispering, 'Oh my God, have you heard?' without being entirely sure what was going on. All became clear a couple of minutes later when, as the bus pulled to a halt, our security guy, Reg Dickason, stood up and announced the attacks. A group of us, including Jimmy, Swanny and Freddie, headed for the communal TV and spent the next four hours or so watching events unfold.

We could barely have been further away from the incidents while being in the same country, since we were staying in the satellite city of Bhubaneswar near Cuttack on the east coast, some 1,000 miles from Mumbai on the west coast, but watching the Taj Mahal Hotel, one of our tour bases, burn was eerie and disturbing. The Middlesex team had been due to arrive the following day; it was all too close to home.